I should have waited before going to see him. I'd expected him to be angry with me. I hadn't expected that I'd lose my temper as well. He told me not to report for the Leeds game, not to meet up with the rest of the team.

I went back downstairs, got changed again and left. I couldn't believe that the boss would leave me out at Leeds because of all this. But that's exactly what he did. I turned up later in the day as I usually would have done, hoping things would blow over. I traveled with everyone to Leeds overnight and the boss announced the team—without me in it—at the hotel the following morning. When we got to the ground he announced the substitutes: I wasn't even on the bench. By then, the whole thing had come out in the papers and there were photographs of me sitting in the stands that afternoon, watching us win 1–0. Thinking back, it seemed as if the publicity surrounding the situation was what really wound things up. I just wonder whether it was the pictures of me coming away from the training ground that Friday, and the stories that came out with them, which forced the manager's hand and made him follow through with the threat to drop me. Might things have been different if the whole business had been taken care of in private?

After the Leeds game, I was away on international duty. When we got back to Manchester, I sat down with the boss, Steve McClaren and Gary Neville to sort things out. That meeting, at least, was out of the public eye, which I'm sure helped us put things straight. After everybody had had their say, the manager summed it up:

'Let's forget this now. Let's get on with things, eh?'

I was genuinely relieved. The boss was the last person in the world I wanted to fall out with. Not just because he's scary when he loses his temper; not just because it could mean me missing games. As far as my soccer career was concerned, the manager was the man who'd made everything possible for me: from day one of my time at Manchester United, he was the father figure in what had become a second family for me. Old Trafford had been home now for almost as long as Mum and Dad's had before it. No matter how angry or hurt I might be about how he was treating me, I understood everything the boss did was motivated by his wanting to do the best for United. And I knew how much he'd done for me personally, as a player and a person, since I'd arrived at Old Trafford as a boy. Maybe how important my relationship with the manager was to me was the reason feelings ran so high.

That afternoon, after training, I was shopping at the Trafford Center. As I came away from the shops to get back in the car, my phone rang. It was the